

KEY

- WHITE TEA
- BLACK AND OOLONG TEA
- PU'ER
- GREEN TEA
- YELLOW TEA



FIRST FLUSH

A tea plucker picking tender new buds in early spring, when nutrients “flush” into the tips of the plant after a dormant winter.

FERMENTATION

After rolling, Pu'er tea is steamed and formed into cakes ready for fermentation. There are two types of Pu'er: sheng (raw) and shou (ripe). Sheng Pu'er is left to ferment naturally, culturing microorganisms slowly over many years, while shou Pu'er is fermented, or aged, over several months in humidity-controlled storage facilities.

OXIDATION

During oxidation, enzymes in the leaf are transformed into theaflavins (informing taste) and thearubigins (informing color). This is achieved by spreading the leaves on tables in a humid environment. The process takes several hours, lasting until the tea master decides that oxidation has concluded (for black tea), or that the desired level has been reached (for oolong).

FIRING/DRYING

Originally done in a basket or wok over charcoal, most tea leaves are now dried in tumble dryers. Some teas, such as Lapsang Souchong black tea and Long jing (Dragon Well) green tea, still use a traditional method as a signature of their style and favor. The finished leaf contains only 3 percent moisture.

SORTING

Once processed, leaves are either hand-sorted or machine-sorted. Some machines have infrared cameras that can detect various sizes of leaf in order to sort them into grades and separate out unwanted elements, such as stems. A well-produced, orthodox tea will have fewer small pieces of leaf and more whole leaves, which are considered a higher grade.

HEAPING

After fixing, yellow tea goes through a step known as “heaping,” or “men huang.” The leaves are laid out in piles for a prolonged resting wrapped in damp cloth. The mixture of heat and humidity gives the leaves a yellow cast.